

responses to the terror of Islam—that familiar left-liberal tone of you-invited-it. After all, the usual suspects of anti-imperialism saw 9/11 as a rejoinder to America's transgressions. "That is what connects the burning book in Bradford to the burning towers in Manhattan: not just the wrath of Islam but also the insecurities of the West," writes Kenan.

Few writers have become a global theme like Rushdie. Today, he is a writer larger than his oeuvre, and no nation can claim complete copyright over him, though the ancestral memories of India continue to enrich his imagination. He is truly a global writer, like Milan Kundera, and he is in permanent argument with the world. The argumentative Rushdie is at his best in his conversa-

EXCERPT

In the end I don't think about the reader. This is a terrible, truthful, horrible admission. I don't care. I never expected to be a best-selling writer. I really never expected that hundreds of thousands of people would go out and buy my books. My process as a writer is to be the servant of the idea, to try and make it work as best I can in all its dimensions, its character, story, language, form. And that frankly is the most difficult thing I've ever found to do. And when I'm doing it, I don't have time to think about how people will respond to it. I guess there is a kind of second me standing over my shoulder trying to see if I like what I'm doing, but frankly I don't know what people are going to like...

-Salman Rushdie in *Midnight's Diaspora*

tions with the political scientist Ashutosh Varshney and the literary scholar Gauri Viswanathan in *Midnight's Diaspora*, which too takes the 20th anniversary of the fatwa as an occasion to celebrate Theme Rushdie. He tells Varshney: "I did say Pakistan was insufficiently imagined, that it was a failure of the dreaming mind. The proof of that is Bangladesh... Saleem in *Midnight's Children* has a line where he describes Pakistan as this strange bird with two wings without a body...". Essayist Husain Haqqani anatomises Rushdie's idea of Pakistan, and Sara Suleri Goodyear takes a look at the metaphor-rich world of Rushdie through a perforated veil. Shashi Tharoor, unlike some of his contemporaries, is modest enough to admit: "As an Indian novelist, I can only repeat what Waugh said of Wodehouse: he is the head of my profession."

Rushdie is a writer who is delightfully trapped in his own stories. The freedom he enjoys can't be contained by the Book. ■

Family Matters

The desperate characters of these stories fight their own loneliness

| By Rajni George |



IF IT IS SWEET
by MRIDULA KOSHY
Tranquebar Press
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Pages: 283

In these seventeen stories are seventeen gritty charters of families and lives torn asunder by conflicts of class, sexuality, love, lust, and most of all, of 'the loneliness of life lived within (the) family'. This last line is taken from *Los Angeles*, the final story in *If It Is Sweet*, Mridula Koshy's literary debut, which charts America's racial tensions in a nice counterpoint to India's own tensions of race, gender and class, present elsewhere in the book. These tales often speak of

domestic help in large Delhi households; of a maid-servant, her lover and her master who observes her with a strange sense of proprietorship (*Romancing the Koodawalla*); of a *presswalli*'s stepdaughter and the rich girl who sort of befriends her, looking for grist for stories she can tell about the unfortunate's life (*Stray Blades of Grass*); of an accident which causes the intersection of a young magazine hawker's life with that of a woman he peddles his wares to (*Same Day*). The author's eye is not limited to this so-called demi monde; or, at least, the demi monde is extended to include an America-returned Indian who has adopted a darker-than-is-beautiful-in-India girl child, with her American husband (*Jane Eyre*). For these are desperate characters, all of them, desperate and hopeful.

Here is a natural stylist, with an easy, accessible turn of phrase. There are some lovely lines; a description of a Malayali meal ends in a lovely proclamation of enjoyment—'she wanted nothing more than to live in her mouth'. Her's is a determined, stealthy eye, born of fierce concentration, often conjuring up a rustic quiet: 'Now her pregnant beauty startles him like the fish that rustle and slip past his shins in the flooded fields of paddy he bends over to seed.' Most admirable is her extended focus on many of her most compelling subjects, members of the working class and the one that aspires to it, though this tenacity is somewhat disturbed by the unevenness in tone; at times it is the idiom of the street that one hears, it turns defiant and plaintive, at times the voice feels a little cultivated. A praiseworthy debut, even if disappointing at times, and an easy read. ■